

BEFORE

In the 18th century, settlers in Britain's American colonies became increasingly intolerant of European rule and paying taxes from which they did not benefit.

COST OF WAR

Britain was ceded French territory in North America during the Anglo-French wars (1754–63) but the cost was high, and the British felt the colonials had failed to pay their share.

PROTEST

Until the 18th century, British **North America** was subject to English law. Settlers thought the new laws passed after 1763 to raise money



BOSTON TEA PARTY

for the British extremely irksome. The Stamp Act, a direct tax on paper, caused riots. In 1773 a group of Bostonians disguised as American Indians threw a cargo of highly taxed EIC tea into Boston Harbor. The American slogan was “no taxation without representation.”

INTOLERABLE ACTS

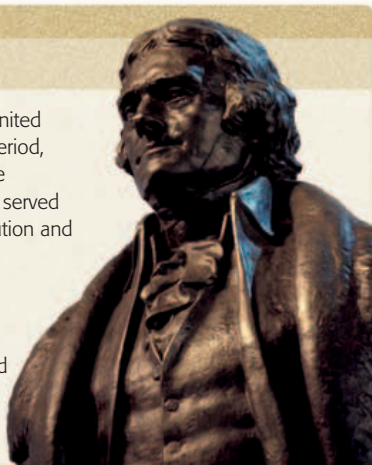
The British response to this episode was rapid. In 1774, laws were passed in reprisal that the Americans dubbed “Intolerable Acts.” Intended to restore order, instead they **united the colonies in further protest**. Fiery leaders began to emerge—they cried out that the actions of the British government were illegal and stirred the colonists to take further action.

AMERICAN PRESIDENT (1743–1826)

THOMAS JEFFERSON

Thomas Jefferson was the third president of the United States. An intellectually outstanding figure of the period, Jefferson was chosen as the principal drafter of the Declaration of Independence at the age of 33. He served as governor of Virginia during the American Revolution and afterward became the first US secretary of state.

Jefferson's vision of the newly created US—as a loose union of self-governing states with central government having limited powers—gave birth to the Democratic Republican Party. Jefferson founded the University of Virginia and died on the 50th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence.



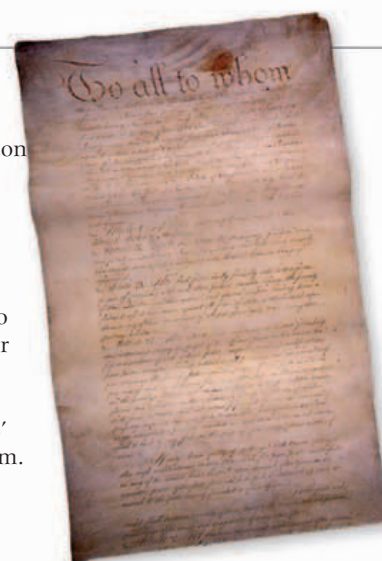
The war between the North American colonies and Britain in 1775 was the predictable climax of years of bitter quarrels between the two sides (see BEFORE).

The first shots were fired in a minor skirmish. On April 19, 1775, General Thomas Gage, commander of the British forces in North America, dispatched troops to seize an arms cache in Concord, a town just outside Boston. In Lexington, Kentucky, the British encountered a small force of American militia (armed civilians). It is unclear which side fired the first shot, but later it was referred to as “the shot heard around the world.” When the British made it back to Boston, they were besieged by militias, and had to wait there for reinforcements. With

On June 15, 1775, George Washington became commander of the new Continental army. He immediately began turning the militias into a more professional fighting force. Washington failed in his attempt to invade Canada in 1775. His men also suffered a major blow in the summer of 1776 when the British captured New York. However, news of the revolts had spread, and the colonists' cause was rapidly gaining momentum.

Independence

The American colonists made their decisive break with Britain on July 4, 1776, when their leaders agreed to the Declaration of Independence. The declaration stated that “life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness” were the



The Articles of Confederation

Adopted by Congress—the formal assembly of government representatives—in 1777, this was the first governing document, or constitution, of the United States, and was ratified by all thirteen states in 1781.

American Declaration of Independence

Until the end of the 18th century, Europe and its colonies were dominated by monarchies. The American Declaration of Independence undermined the old order and proclaimed a new republic in which people would be free to govern themselves.

their arrival on May 26, Gage decided to capture hill positions that overlooked Boston. The resulting Battle of Bunker Hill in June 1775 was a disaster. Although they captured the hill positions, half the British troops were wounded or killed, and they failed to break the American siege of Boston.

“unalienable rights of all men,” and when a government tried to destroy these rights, it was “the Right of the People to alter or abolish it, and to institute new government.” The signing of the Declaration of Independence was a momentous event, and made a peaceful settlement with the British much less likely. It was largely the work of Thomas Jefferson (see left).

Washington had won important battles in what is now New Jersey—in Trenton on December 26, 1776 and Princeton on January 3, 1777—which reinforced his reputation. On March 2, 1776, with a force of over 17,000 men and a buildup of artillery stocks, the Americans began bombarding the blockaded British troops in Boston. They were forced to depart for Halifax, Nova Scotia. Although the British went on to capture New York, an American victory at nearby Saratoga in October 1777 stirred French interest in an alliance with the colonies. On February 6, 1778 France and America signed treaties of alliance. It was a major turning point—the Americans were no longer fighting alone.

All hope of a British victory ended on October 19, 1781. Lord Cornwallis was forced to surrender at Yorktown, Virginia, after an 18-day siege.

Declaration of Independence

This painting by John Trumbull depicts the committee of five who drafted the Declaration of Independence, presenting it to the Continental Congress on July 4, 1776.

“Oh, God! It's all over.”

PRIME MINISTER LORD NORTH, ON HEARING OF THE SURRENDER OF THE BRITISH TROOPS TO THE AMERICANS, 1781